

Inside The Xbox

A 360 degree view on Microsoft's second gaming console

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Sony's monster brand of PlayStation has been dominating the console scene ever since its inception. The first of that console's line usurped the crown from Nintendo and has been unstoppable ever since—selling more than 100 million hardware units and up to a billion software units. Lately, Sony has been positioning the PlayStation 3 as a unit to replace the computer—with Linux on its 20 GB or 60 GB hard drive, keyboard support, a Web browser and HD resolution out of the box (up to 1920 × 1080), “the PC is no longer needed”, Sony points. With a 100 million hardware base, the PS3 is thus a very real threat to the Microsoft domination of the PC market. Microsoft, of course saw this coming a mile away, more precisely, around the year 2000 when it took its first steps into the console business. 2000 is when Microsoft approached Gigapixel; getting the ball rolling on what would be the Xbox brand.

Both Sony and Microsoft would like their products to sit next to your television—serving all manner of content from games, to music and movie downloads. The potential market is huge, the money pot at the end of this rainbow, astronomical. While the business of consoles is intriguing, this article will take a look at what's inside one of the two, so-called, “next-generation” offerings—Microsoft's Xbox 360.

The architecture of the Xbox 360 is unique in many aspects but hardware alone does not make a system. Some would say that the Xbox 360's unique strength lies with its LIVE component—an online matchmaking service, a marketplace, a gaming playground, all rolled into one—LIVE is what makes the 360. We will thus have a brief look at both these aspects of the console—the hardware and the software.

Sins Of The Father

Back when Microsoft was kicking around the concept of the first Xbox, the team in-charge of bringing the console to fruition did not have the luxury of time—they were already launching after the PlayStation 2 and they needed to get the product out at once or lose market traction. Due to this, the Xbox was practically made up of off-the-shelf computer parts: a slightly modified Intel processor, some memory, a Seagate hard drive, a slightly modified NVIDIA video chipset, thrown together in a huge, ugly cabinet.

It wasn't the prettiest of engineering but it got the job done: the Xbox sold around